

extend the use of our ageing desktop PCs, as Ubuntu required comparatively less compute power than other proprietary OSs,” explains Balaranjith T.

The open source team at Atul Limited also started developing several custom solutions on the LAMP (Linux, Apache, MySQL and PHP) platform during the same time. The team primarily started using PHP and MySQL, as both were easy to learn but were more powerful than most of the proprietary technologies. Some of the solutions developed were a vendor portal for entering quotations by the firm’s various suppliers, a time-keeping solution for leave and attendance monitoring, an employee performance monitoring portal, etc. Most of the IT team members were trained through an in-house team on the LAMP platform.

“In 2012, we were searching for a data warehousing solution for our ERP data. While going through the Gartner Magic Quadrant, we came across a solution called Pentaho, which was reviewed as the best open source data warehousing solution. We did a comparative study of Pentaho with other industry leading proprietary solutions. We found that Pentaho performs equally well if not much better than most of the proprietary solutions. We started implementation in late 2012. Initially, we had planned to have Oracle as the back-end database because the source system was Oracle E-Business Suite (EBS). But, during implementation, we used MySQL as it is more scalable,” shares Balaranjith.

The IT team also used Pentaho’s reporting feature on top of this solution for its normal reporting requirements and Saiku for business analytics. The team used community editions for both the solutions. Hence, Balaranjith reports, Atul Limited got itself a 100 per cent open source data warehousing and business intelligence solution, which is very unique (Oracle OLTP to MySQL OLAP). Since the implementation in March 2013, the company has migrated most of its reports from Oracle EBS to the data warehousing solution. This has also improved the performance of Oracle EBS as it now handles only transaction processing.

The firm uses open source in almost every domain including operating systems (both servers and end user desktops), data warehousing, business analytics, a document management solution, help desk ticketing, and more. “A range of business-critical applications are developed on open source technologies. The tools used are LAMP, Ubuntu, RedHat Linux, Pentaho Kettle, Mondrain, Saiku Analytics, Ajaxplorer, Mantis, and a lot more,” adds Balaranjith.

The migration tale

Balaranjith explains in detail how the team migrated from proprietary solutions and took the FOSS route to success. “We have migrated from an AIX-based platform to a Linux-based platform. This was done when we migrated to Intel Xeon-based servers, which run much



Balaranjith T, general manager, IT,
Atul Limited

better on Linux and are very secure and stable. Right now, more than 80 per cent of our servers use the Linux platform. We have also migrated many of our PCs from Windows to Ubuntu, which is more secure and stable than Windows. Being less resource hungry, the Ubuntu machines can extend the life of the PC hardware by a couple of years, compared to

machines with similar hardware running on the Windows platform. Right now, we run a hybrid environment of both Ubuntu and Windows machines in our enterprise.”

The early bottlenecks

Since the firm does all the development and deployment with the help of its in-house IT technical brigade, training the team on open source technology was a big challenge. Throwing some light on the process, Balaranjith opines, “Not many companies in India have the training skills for the open source solutions domain. Hence, we had to research on our own through various forums and blogs to learn and adopt the best practices on open source implementation. But doing our own research and learning also has its advantages. Our team has gained more expertise on OSS due to extensive research on various portals. Another major problem is the lack of updates on certain OSS. So while prospecting for a solution, we normally check the history of the product and its support forum. We also check the availability of the subscription model for support as we might need that in the future. Based on our checks, we finalise on an OSS.”

Challenges in the offing

Open source technology is quickly gaining momentum in the Indian business landscape. Trained IT resources are very much in demand in the market as more and more Indian manufacturing companies are getting aware about the advantages of adopting the open source model. According to Balaranjith, retaining trained talent to run the open source applications will be a huge challenge for the company in the near future. “On one side, it is really good for the engineer who is working on the solution. But the challenge for the enterprise is to train and retain the top talent. The second major challenge is whether the OSS will be able to update itself with respect to the fast changing technology landscape. For example, now business users want all solutions to work on their tablets. With OSS, especially FOSS, the support updates and enhancements don’t come as fast as in the case